

Change Is a Must: Interpersonal Expectancy, Featuring Steve Olson

Steve Olson, Distinguished Lecturer, UT Chattanooga

“To outsiders, I’m that mean lady on the sidelines yelling at my players, but I’m determined to get the maximum potential out of them. I don’t care if I have to coax, pull, push, or haul it out of them. When I challenge them, what I’m really saying is, ‘You’re better than this and you don’t even know it.’”

Pat always considered herself to be a teacher, and she realized that driving people to change, challenging them to improve, was at the heart of being a good teacher.

Coach Pat Summitt

Are you going to come along and run this basketball team or are you going to play like you’re scared out of your mind? You start the game with a turnover. It’s time for you to grow up right here and everybody else follows your lead and plays nervous.

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So, what made Pat Summitt more successful? It’s quite simple, really, but it’s also quite rare. Pat really believed that her players, all of them, could meet her high standards for excellence. Scientists call this high expectation the interpersonal expectancy effect, and it is one of the most powerful drivers of high performance. If this sounds a bit like Pat Summitt and the effect that her sorority sisters had on her, it should. It’s the same principle. In fact, the belief and expectation that someone can do something if they’re just willing to stay at it long enough to learn it is so powerful that armies around the world have tried to harness the effect.

Sadly, scientists discovered that you can’t teach the effect. It has to be believed. You have to really believe that others can meet your highest standards. So, where does the belief that others can meet the highest standards come from? It comes from ourselves. *We* have to really believe that *we* can do it. Researchers call this belief self-efficacy, and it’s the single most important factor in an individual’s success. You won’t be surprised, then, to learn that Pat Summitt had the highest self-efficacy you can imagine, and she held the same belief about her players.